

than the Fujitsu LBS6240, whereas the latter scored higher in usability, package contents and flaunt value. It was a close call, and the margin was too slim to declare either of these a winner. A tie was called for, and the *Digit* 'Best Buy Silver' was awarded jointly to the Acer TravelMate 3002WTCi and the Fujitsu Lifebook LBS6240.

The Sony VAIO VGN-S46GP/S costs Rs 99,990, which is moderate for a lifestyle laptop with the kind of features it includes. It scored well in almost every segment, and even has the highest flaunt value rating. It wins the *Digit* 'Best Buy Gold' by a big margin.

LIFESTYLE WORKHORSES

'Workhorse' laptops are designed to be desktop replacements, so weight and size generally aren't considered that important. But we were comparing lifestyle laptops here—the ones we tested even in this category certainly did not resemble briefcases! They were also rich on features and looks, but, of course, were a little less portable than those in the previous category. These laptops are the kind that corporate bigwigs such as CEOs, chairmen, and so on would use, and these will, generally speaking, adorn the living rooms of the rich and famous.

As we said earlier, the laptops were categorised as ultra-portables and workhorses based on screen size and weight. The workhorse category comprised laptops that had a diagonal screen size of more than 14 inches and weighed over two kg, and which therefore had a larger form factor.

Eight laptops from six brands emerged in this category. These included the Acer Ferrari 4002, the Fujitsu LifeBook LBN3510, the IBM ThinkPad T43, the MSI MegaBooks M520 and M630, and the Samsung R50 and X20.

Features

The Processor

Most of the laptops here were based on Intel processors and motherboards, with the exception of the Acer Ferrari 4002, which featured the AMD Turion 64 ML-30 processor—and the MSI MegaBook M630, which had an AMD Sempron 2800+. The MSI Megabook M520 had a Pentium M 1600 MHz processor. The rest featured Intel Pentium M 1733 MHz processors.

The RAM

The MSI Megabook M630 and the IBM T43 had 256 MB, and the rest were equipped with 512 MB of memory. The Fujitsu LBN3510, IBM T43, LG LW60 Express and both the Samsung laptops had DDR2 memory. The rest featured DDR memory.

The Display

Five of the eight laptops featured a 15.4-inch display. The MSI MegaBook M520 and the Samsung X20 each featured a 15-inch display. The IBM T43 featured the smallest of the displays at 14.1-inches.

The IBM T43, the MSI MegaBook M520 and the Samsung X20 featured an LCD display with a normal aspect ratio and a native screen resolution of 1024 x 768, whereas the other laptops featured

wide screens and a native resolution of 1280 x 800. Like the Sony VAIO in the previous category, the Fujitsu LBN3510 had the best display in this category, with very large viewing angles.

Ports And Connectivity

Four of the laptops had four USB ports each. The IBM T43 had only two. All the laptops had a FireWire port for high-speed video capture from supported hardware. Though serial ports were not available on any of these laptops, a parallel port was provided in the IBM T43 and the LG LW60. Only the Acer Ferrari, IBM T43 and LG LW60 had infrared. The Acer Ferrari, IBM T43 and S270 and the Samsung laptops had Bluetooth.

All the laptops were Wi-Fi conformant with the b+g high-speed standard, except for the MSI Megabook M630 and the Acer Ferrari 4002, which had the slower WiFi 802.11g. The Acer, IBM and Samsung X20 had Gigabit Ethernet, whereas the rest had 10/100. All the laptops had 56 Kbps modems.



Acer Ferrari 4002

Multimedia

Every laptop had a microphone-in and headphone-out. D-Sub and S-Video out was also featured on all the laptops. The Samsung laptops, the Fujitsu LBN3510 and the MSI Megabook M520 even had a standalone DVD/Audio CD player—you can activate the player before you boot into the OS!

Multimedia and memory card reading capability was featured on all the laptops except for the IBM T43 and the MSI Megabook M630. The Samsung R50 and the Acer Ferrari supported most types of memory cards—SD, MMC, MS, MS Pro and XD.

Other features

The Fujitsu LBN3510 came with the highest capacity hard drive—100 GB—followed by the Acer Ferrari with an 80 GB. The IBM and the MSI Megabook M630 only had 40 GB hard disks.

The MSI, LG and Fujitsu had slower 4200 rpm hard drives, while the rest were at 5400 rpm.